

Fig. 1.1: Ashoka and his queen on a second century CE panel of the Kanaganahalli stupa in Karnataka

Unlike the anonymous soothsayers of Champa, this Ajivika mendicant was not a faceless entity. He is introduced to us as Pingalavatsajiva, a religious man who was requested by none other than Bindusara to examine his sons. This was because the ascetic had the gift of scrutiny, in this case the power to recognize who would rule best after Bindusara's death. Initially, Ashoka was unwilling to be examined, for his father is said to have